

Thematic Analysis

Braun & Clarke's six phases — the workhorse of qualitative analysis

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Thematic analysis (TA) is a method for systematically identifying, analysing and reporting patterns (themes) across qualitative data. Braun and Clarke's six-phase approach is the most widely used in business and management research because it is flexible, transparent and accessible. A theme captures something important about the data in relation to the research question — it is actively constructed by the researcher, not passively 'found' (Braun and Clarke, 2006).

WHAT A THEME IS

A theme is a pattern of meaning, not just a frequent word. It answers part of your research question and unites disparate data extracts under one idea. Themes have sub-themes; together they form a coherent, non-overlapping structure that tells the story of your data.

INDUCTIVE vs THEORETICAL

Inductive (bottom-up): themes emerge from the data with no pre-set frame — best for exploratory work. Theoretical (top-down): data coded against an existing framework — best when testing a theory. State which you used, and stay consistent.

The six phases. (1) Familiarise yourself with the data. (2) Generate initial codes. (3) Search for themes. (4) Review themes against the data. (5) Define and name themes. (6) Produce the report, weaving extracts with interpretation. The phases are recursive — you move back and forth, not strictly forward.

Phase	What you do	Output
1 Familiarisation	Read, re-read, note ideas	Immersion, initial notes
2 Coding	Label meaningful segments	Coded dataset
3 Searching	Cluster codes into candidate themes	Theme map
4 Reviewing	Check themes against data	Refined themes
5 Defining	Name and scope each theme	Theme definitions
6 Writing	Weave extracts + interpretation	Analytic narrative

KEEP A CODEBOOK

Record your codes and their definitions. It makes analysis auditable and helps consistency if you code over several sessions.

EXTRACTS + ANALYSIS

Quotes alone are not analysis. Every extract needs your interpretation of what it means for the research question.

SHOW THE TRAIL

An appendix with your coding framework and a worked example demonstrates rigour and protects against 'where did this come from?'.

Common pitfalls. (1) Themes that are just data-collection questions relabelled. (2) A 'bucket' theme called 'miscellaneous'. (3) Presenting quotes with no interpretation. (4) Claiming inductive analysis while coding to a hidden framework. (5) Overlapping, non-distinct themes.

REFERENCES

Braun, V. and Clarke, V. (2006) 'Using thematic analysis in psychology', *Qualitative Research in Psychology*, 3(2), pp. 77-101. · Braun, V. and Clarke, V. (2022) *Thematic Analysis: A Practical Guide*. London: SAGE.